

FOREST EXPLORER

Teacher notes | Grades 5-7 | 40-60 minutes



A deeper investigation of trees and the living relationships around them. A stand of schoolyard trees is enough; a forest park offers more examples. Students separate observation from inference and look for change over time.

Route & access

Walk the site first. Choose a shared route and observation stations with stable surfaces and rest options. Every student should be able to make discoveries and direct part of the inquiry.

Materials

Print student pages; bring pencils and clipboards if useful. Sketches, labels, oral notes, or photographs (where permitted) are valid records.

Learning flow

5 min: settle and listen. 25-35 min: complete five of nine missions. 10 min: exchange claims and evidence. 5 min: choose a return question.

Care for place

Set boundaries and a meeting point. Stay on permitted paths; observe without picking, tasting, digging, feeding wildlife, or moving habitat materials.

Evidence to listen for

Ask: "Which clues support your claim?" "Could there be another explanation?" "What might a return visit reveal?"

FOREST EXPLORER



Name: _____ Date: _____ Place: _____

Choose challenges in any order. Record what you saw before explaining it.

01 FOREST LAYERS

Observe the ground, understory, and canopy from a safe position. Record life or evidence in two layers.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Two layers and their clues

EVIDENCE + THINKING

How are they connected?

02 TREE PORTRAIT

Choose one tree. Record shape, bark, branches, and surroundings so someone else could find it.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

A labelled close-up

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What makes it distinctive?

03 DECOMPOSITION CLUES

Find fallen material at different stages of breakdown. Look without moving it.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Colour, texture, location

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What may happen next?

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04 LIGHT MOSAIC

Compare two places with different light. Observe plants, ground, and moisture.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

A two-place comparison

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What role might light play?

05 LIVING RELATIONSHIP

Find evidence that two living things affect one another. Avoid assuming you know the exact species.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Describe both clues

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What relationship is possible?

06 FOREST SOUND MAP

Listen in silence for one minute. Mark near and far sounds on a map.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Direction and distance

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What can sound reveal unseen?

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Choose challenges in any order. Record what you saw before explaining it.

07 PATTERN WITH EXCEPTIONS

Find a repeated form in leaves, bark, roots, or branches. Look for an exception.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Pattern and exception

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What might explain variation?

08 SIGNS OF CHANGE

Look for a clue of growth, decay, weather, or human action.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

Sketch the strongest clue

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What timeline is plausible?

09 A TESTABLE QUESTION

Write a question that could be answered through a safe return visit or repeated observations.

OBSERVE / SKETCH

What we know now

EVIDENCE + THINKING

What should we record later?

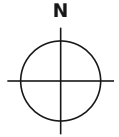
FOREST EXPLORER

Map the place, then share one discovery with a partner



Draw a map of your route or observation area. Add a key and mark your strongest evidence.

FIELD MAP / CLOSE-UP



Key: _____

My claim about this place:

Evidence that supports it:

A different explanation or a new question:

FOREST EXPLORER



Return to the same observation point

First visit: _____ Return visit: _____ Weather: _____

BEFORE / SKETCH + NOTES

NOW / SKETCH + NOTES

What changed? Use at least two specific observations.

What stayed similar? What might explain both the change and the pattern?

How could our class care for this place without disturbing it?
